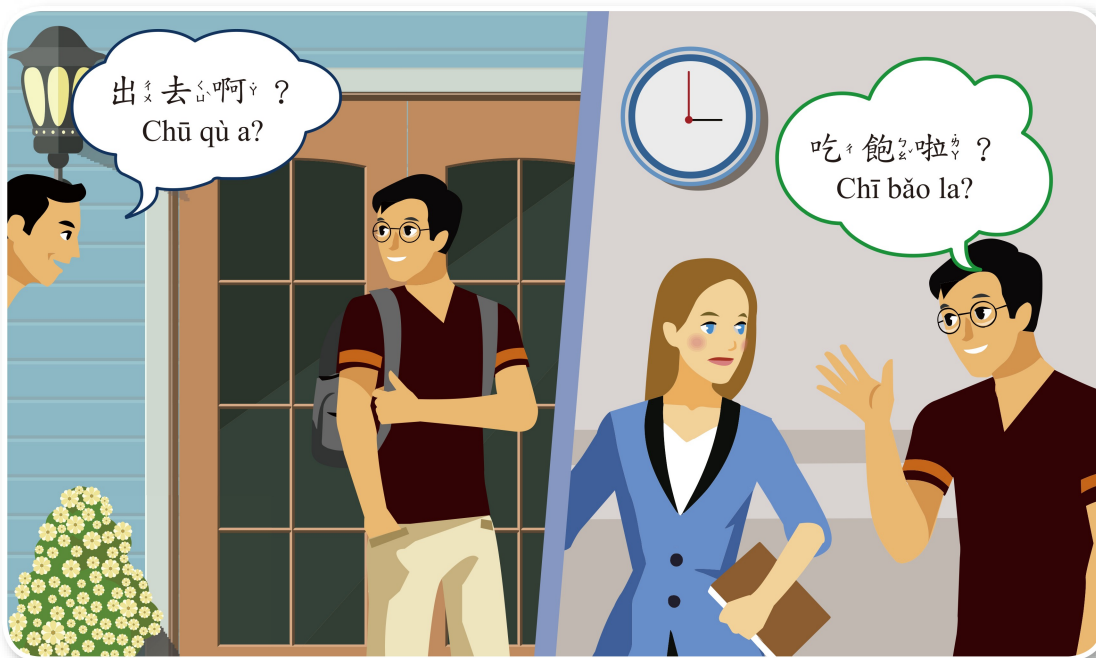


文化單元 (二) Culture Notes

How Do People Greet Each Other in Taiwan



Do you find it interesting that your neighbors ask you “去上班啊？Qù shàng bān a? Going to work?” or “出去啊？Chū qù a? Are you going out?” upon seeing you go out work in the mornings? Sometimes, your friends ask you “Done with your lunch?” upon seeing you around two or three o’clock in the afternoon. Why would they ask you questions with such obvious answers? The answer is that these questions are common and cordial ways for people in Taiwan to greet one another. You may recall that you learned “你好” on the first day of your Mandarin class, so why isn’t “你好” used by people in Taiwan on a daily basis? It is actually normal in our culture in Taiwan to greet family and acquaintances with these “stating the obvious” type of questions.

In addition to saying “你好”, there are some other common expressions such as “吃飽啦？(Chī bǎo la? Are you full?)” “吃飯啊？(Chī fàn a? Going to eat?)” “去上課啊？(Qù shàng kè Going to school?)” “回來啦！(Huí lái la? Just came back?)” “你好” is more commonly used when meeting someone for the first time or upon formal occasions. The speaker does not expect an elaborate answer and you can simply respond “是啊！(Shì a! Yes!)” “對啊！(Duì a! Yes)” In the future, do not be surprised if you encounter people who greet you with these “stating the obvious” type questions. They are simply saying hello and communicating concern / care.